Plenum appointments provide bridge to a rebuilt military

送信者: EG China 受信日時: 2026-10-30 01:59

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What Happened

The CCP Central Committee's 5th plenum elevated current Central Military Commission (CMC) Vice Chairman Zhang Shengmin to the Politburo.

Our Take

Zhang is Xi's bridge from a purged military to a rebuilt one, but the construction is far from complete. Zhang's elevation restores the norm that CMC vice chairmen sit on the Politburo, a practice that was interrupted last January with the ouster of Zhang Youxia. Promoting him now, a year before the 2027 Party Congress, suggests that Xi intends Zhang to span both sides of that transition, anchoring a hollowed-out command structure today and laying the groundwork for the rebuilt one tomorrow. The plenum did not address the other five empty CMC seats. The CMC now has no other officers besides Zhang. Acting officers have been named, and those seats will not be officially filled until the 21st Party Congress in late 2027 (see: CCP will benefit from stability and promote economic managers in 2027, 2 September 2026).

The retirement math reinforces this interpretation. Zhang will be 69 at the time of the 2027 Congress, one year past the customary retirement age for his rank. His promotion now points to Xi waiving that norm to keep him in his post (see: Next leadership cycle will harden centralization around Xi , 22 October 2026), cementing his role as the main source of continuity in the military command structure into the next leadership term.

Low attendance at the 5th Plenum shows Xi's disciplinary campaign is still reshaping the Central Committee. About 21% of full members and 32% of alternates selected in 2022 were absent. At the same meeting in 2021, only 3% of full members and 12% of alternates did not attend. Absence alone doesn't prove someone is under investigation, but the scale of the increase—a sixfold jump among full members—points to continued turmoil at senior levels. With a year to go before the 2027 congress, Xi still has substantial vetting to do before he finalizes the Central Committee's composition.

Xi continues to distrust his military leadership. The plenum's appointments do not change our view that the near-term probability of a Taiwan conflict remains very low at 5% (see: Beijing's growing confidence will heighten Taiwan risk after 2028 , 15 September 2026). Xi left five CMC seats empty and passed over military alternates for promotion, including two deputy commanders of the People's Armed Police. That suggests he is still vetting his top officers rather than fully relying on them or preparing for a near-term conflict. Xi is unlikely to order a high-risk military operation under commanders he has not yet confirmed in their posts. The 2027 Congress remains the window for him to finally reconstitute the military leadership.

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